

CLINICAL KNOWLEDGE SUMMARY (CKS-STYLE, ORIGINAL CONTENT)

Combined Conditions: 10 Common UK Health Presentations

(LLM-generated for AI development — not derived from NICE content)

1. Arthritis & Joint Pain

Clinical Summary

Arthritis and joint pain are highly prevalent in the UK and represent a major cause of disability and reduced quality of life. Presentations range from mild, intermittent discomfort to persistent inflammatory disease. Osteoarthritis is the most common form, driven by gradual cartilage degeneration, while inflammatory types such as rheumatoid arthritis involve autoimmune processes. Symptoms typically include stiffness, reduced mobility, and pain that worsens with activity. Inflammatory forms may present with warmth, swelling, and prolonged morning stiffness. Although many cases respond well to conservative management, clinicians must remain alert to red-flag features such as a hot, swollen joint with fever, which may indicate septic arthritis.

Background Information

Causes

- Osteoarthritis: cartilage degeneration
- Rheumatoid arthritis: autoimmune inflammation
- Gout: uric acid crystal deposition
- Mechanical strain or injury
- Obesity and ageing

Prevalence

Affects around 10 million people in the UK.

Complications

- Reduced mobility
- Sleep disturbance
- Joint deformity
- Increased fall risk

Prognosis

Osteoarthritis progresses slowly; inflammatory arthritis may fluctuate but improves with early treatment.

Diagnosis

History

- Pain pattern, stiffness duration
- Functional impact
- Systemic symptoms

Examination

- Swelling, warmth, tenderness
- Range of motion
- Gait assessment

Differential Diagnosis

- Gout
 - Septic arthritis
 - Bursitis
 - Tendinopathy
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Management

Non-pharmacological

- Exercise and strengthening
- Weight optimisation
- Physiotherapy
- Joint protection

Pharmacological

- Paracetamol
- NSAIDs (oral or topical)
- Corticosteroid injections for flares

Prescribing Information

- **NSAIDs:** Use lowest effective dose; consider gastroprotection.
 - **Topical NSAIDs:** Useful for localised pain.
 - **Steroid injections:** Avoid frequent use; monitor for infection.
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2. High Blood Pressure (Hypertension)

Clinical Summary

Hypertension is a major cardiovascular risk factor and often presents without symptoms. Many individuals remain undiagnosed until complications arise. Risk increases with age, obesity, smoking, and family history. Although usually asymptomatic, severe hypertension may present with headaches, visual disturbance, chest pain, or neurological symptoms. Early detection and treatment significantly reduce long-term cardiovascular risk.

Background Information

Causes

- Primary hypertension (most cases)
- Secondary causes: renal disease, endocrine disorders, medications

Prevalence

Affects over 16% of adults in NHS surveys.

Complications

- Stroke
- Heart attack
- Kidney disease
- Heart failure

Prognosis

Good with treatment; untreated hypertension increases morbidity.

Diagnosis

Assessment

- Repeated BP measurements
- Home or ambulatory monitoring
- Cardiovascular risk assessment

Investigations

- Renal function
 - Electrolytes
 - Lipid profile
 - Urinalysis
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Management

Lifestyle

- Salt reduction
- Weight loss
- Exercise
- Reduced alcohol intake

Pharmacological

- ACE inhibitors
 - Calcium channel blockers
 - Thiazide-type diuretics
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Prescribing Information

- **ACE inhibitors:** Monitor renal function and potassium.
 - **CCBs:** May cause ankle swelling.
 - **Thiazides:** Monitor electrolytes; may trigger gout.
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3. Depression & Anxiety

Clinical Summary

Depression and anxiety are among the most common mental health conditions in the UK. They often develop gradually and may be triggered by stress, trauma, chronic illness, or social factors. Symptoms include persistent low mood, loss of interest, sleep disturbance, irritability, and physical symptoms such as palpitations. Red-flag features include suicidal thoughts, self-harm, or psychotic symptoms.

Background Information

Causes

- Genetic vulnerability
- Stressful life events
- Chronic illness
- Social isolation

Prevalence

Highly prevalent across all age groups.

Complications

- Substance misuse
- Self-harm
- Reduced functioning

Prognosis

Most improve with treatment; relapse is common.

Diagnosis

Assessment

- Mood, sleep, appetite
- Functional impact
- Risk assessment

Differential Diagnosis

- Thyroid disorders
- Anaemia
- Medication side effects

Management

Non-pharmacological

- CBT
- Counselling
- Exercise
- Sleep hygiene

Pharmacological

- SSRIs first-line
- SNRIs or other agents if needed

Prescribing Information

- **SSRIs:** Start low; monitor early anxiety.
- **SNRIs:** Useful for combined pain and mood symptoms.
- **All antidepressants:** Review after 2–4 weeks.

4. Respiratory Infections (Cold/Flu/COVID-19)

Clinical Summary

Respiratory infections are the most common acute illnesses in the UK. Most are viral and self-limiting, presenting with cough, sore throat, fever, and fatigue. Red-flag symptoms include severe breathlessness, chest pain, confusion, or low oxygen saturation.

Background Information

Causes

- Rhinovirus
- Influenza
- SARS-CoV-2

Prevalence

Extremely common, especially in winter.

Complications

- Pneumonia
- Dehydration
- Exacerbation of asthma/COPD

Prognosis

Most recover within 1–2 weeks.

Diagnosis

Assessment

- Temperature
- Respiratory rate
- Oxygen saturation
- Chest sounds

Differential Diagnosis

- Pneumonia
 - Asthma exacerbation
 - Heart failure
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Management

Supportive

- Rest
- Fluids
- Paracetamol/ibuprofen

Pharmacological

- Antivirals in high-risk cases
 - Antibiotics only if bacterial infection suspected
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Prescribing Information

- **Antibiotics:** Avoid unless clear bacterial features.
 - **Antivirals:** Reserved for high-risk influenza.
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5. Asthma & COPD

Clinical Summary

Asthma and COPD are major causes of respiratory morbidity. Asthma is characterised by reversible airway obstruction, while COPD is progressive and linked to smoking. Symptoms include wheeze, breathlessness, and cough. Red-flag features include a silent chest, cyanosis, or exhaustion.

Background Information

Causes

- Asthma: allergens, viral infections
- COPD: smoking, occupational exposure

Prevalence

High in the UK; major cause of emergency admissions.

Complications

- Respiratory failure
- Frequent exacerbations

Prognosis

Asthma often well-controlled; COPD is progressive.

Diagnosis

Assessment

- Peak flow
- Spirometry
- Trigger identification

Differential Diagnosis

- Heart failure
- Anxiety-related breathlessness

Management

Asthma

- Inhaled corticosteroids
- Reliever inhaler
- Action plan

COPD

- Bronchodilators
- Pulmonary rehabilitation
- Smoking cessation

Prescribing Information

- **ICS:** Rinse mouth after use.
- **LABA/LAMA:** Improve COPD symptoms.
- **Oral steroids:** Short courses only.

6. Diabetes (Type 1 & Type 2)

Clinical Summary

Diabetes is a major chronic condition affecting millions in the UK. Type 1 results from autoimmune destruction of insulin-producing cells, while Type 2 is driven by insulin resistance. Symptoms include thirst, frequent urination, and fatigue. Red-flag features include vomiting, abdominal pain, or confusion.

Background Information

Causes

- Type 1: autoimmune
- Type 2: obesity, genetics

Prevalence

Affects ~8% of the UK population.

Complications

- Kidney disease
- Retinopathy
- Neuropathy
- Cardiovascular disease

Prognosis

Good with early control; complications increase with poor control.

Diagnosis

Investigations

- HbA1c
- Fasting glucose
- Urine ketones

Differential Diagnosis

- Stress hyperglycaemia
 - Medication-induced hyperglycaemia
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Management

Type 1

- Insulin therapy
- Carbohydrate counting

Type 2

- Lifestyle changes
 - Metformin first-line
 - Additional agents as needed
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Prescribing Information

- **Metformin:** GI side effects; avoid in severe renal impairment.
- **Insulin:** Risk of hypoglycaemia.

- **SGLT2 inhibitors:** Risk of genital infections.
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7. Eczema / Dermatitis

Clinical Summary

Eczema is a chronic inflammatory skin condition characterised by dryness, itching, and flare-ups. It often begins in childhood. Red-flag features include widespread infection or rapidly spreading redness.

Background Information

Causes

- Genetic predisposition
- Allergens
- Irritants
- Stress

Prevalence

Very common, especially in children.

Complications

- Infection
- Sleep disturbance

Prognosis

Chronic but manageable.

Diagnosis

Assessment

- Distribution
- Severity
- Signs of infection

Differential Diagnosis

- Psoriasis
- Fungal infection

Management

Non-pharmacological

- Emollients
- Avoid irritants

Pharmacological

- Topical steroids
- Antihistamines

Prescribing Information

- **Topical steroids:** Use lowest potency needed.
- **Emollients:** Apply frequently.

8. Gastroenteritis

Clinical Summary

Gastroenteritis presents with vomiting, diarrhoea, and abdominal cramps. Most cases are viral and self-limiting. Red-flag features include dehydration, blood in stool, or persistent vomiting.

Background Information

Causes

- Viral (most common)
- Bacterial
- Foodborne

Prevalence

Common across all age groups.

Complications

- Dehydration
- Electrolyte imbalance

Prognosis

Usually resolves within 48–72 hours.

Diagnosis

Assessment

- Hydration status
- Travel history
- Stool characteristics

Differential Diagnosis

- Appendicitis
 - IBS flare
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Management

Supportive

- Oral rehydration
- Light diet

Pharmacological

- Anti-emetics
 - Avoid anti-diarrhoeals in children
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Prescribing Information

- **ORS:** Use small frequent sips.
 - **Anti-emetics:** Use cautiously in children.
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9. Heart Disease

Clinical Summary

Heart disease includes angina, heart failure, and acute coronary syndromes. Symptoms include chest pain, breathlessness, and fatigue. Red-flag features include crushing chest pain or collapse.

Background Information

Causes

- Atherosclerosis
- Hypertension
- Diabetes
- Smoking

Prevalence

Leading cause of death in the UK.

Complications

- Heart attack
- Heart failure
- Arrhythmias

Prognosis

Improves with early intervention.

Diagnosis

Assessment

- Chest pain history
- Risk factors
- ECG

Differential Diagnosis

- Musculoskeletal pain
 - Reflux
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Management

Lifestyle

- Diet
- Exercise
- Smoking cessation

Pharmacological

- Statins
 - Antiplatelets
 - Beta-blockers
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Prescribing Information

- **Statins:** Monitor liver function.
 - **Antiplatelets:** Bleeding risk.
 - **Beta-blockers:** Avoid in severe asthma.
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10. Allergies & Hay Fever

Clinical Summary

Allergies and hay fever are extremely common in the UK. Symptoms include sneezing, itchy eyes, and runny nose. Red-flag features include anaphylaxis or breathing difficulty.

Background Information

Causes

- Pollen
- Dust mites
- Animals
- Foods

Prevalence

One of the most common chronic conditions.

Complications

- Sinusitis
- Asthma flare
- Anaphylaxis

Prognosis

Generally good with treatment.

Diagnosis

Assessment

- Trigger history
- Symptom pattern

Differential Diagnosis

- Viral rhinitis
- Non-allergic rhinitis

Management

Non-pharmacological

- Allergen avoidance
- Pollen monitoring

Pharmacological

- Antihistamines
- Nasal corticosteroids

Prescribing Information

- **Antihistamines:** Non-sedating preferred.
- **Nasal steroids:** Use daily for best effect.